6 Reasons Why Your VLOOKUP is Not Working

Apr 9

by Alan Murray | updated on September 4, 2017 112 Comments

The VLOOKUP function is the most popular lookup and reference function in Excel. It is also one of the trickiest and the dreaded #N/A error message can be a common sight.

This article will look at the 6 most common reasons why your VLOOKUP is not working.

1. You Need an Exact Match
2. Lock the Table Reference
3. A Column Has Been Inserted
4. The Table has got Bigger
5. VLOOKUP Cannot Look to its Left
6. Your Table Contains Duplicates

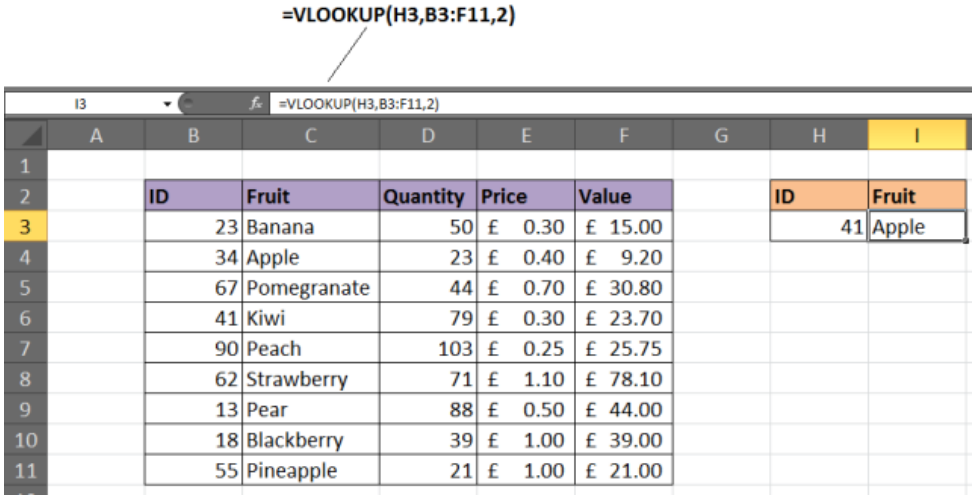
You Need an Exact Match

The last argument of the VLOOKUP function, known as *range_lookup*, asks if you would like an approximate or an exact match.

In most cases people are looking for a particular product, order, employee or customer and therefore require an exact match. When looking for a unique value, FALSE should be entered for the *range_lookup* argument.

This argument is optional, but if left empty, the TRUE value is used. The TRUE value relies on your data being sorted in ascending order to work.

The image below shows a VLOOKUP with the range_lookup argument omitted, and the incorrect value being returned.



ID	Fruit	Quantity	Price	Value
23	Banana	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
34	Apple	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
67	Pomegranate	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
41	Kiwi	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
90	Peach	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
62	Strawberry	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
13	Pear	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
18	Blackberry	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
55	Pineapple	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00

ID	Fruit
41	Apple

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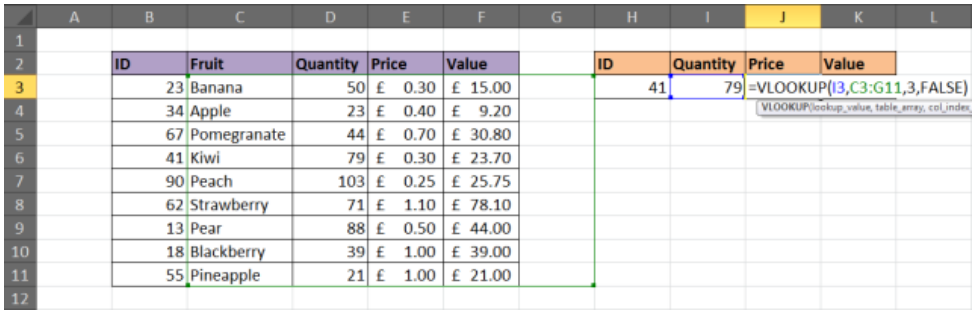
If looking for a unique value, enter FALSE for the last argument. The VLOOKUP above should be entered as `=VLOOKUP(H3,B3:F11,2,FALSE)`.

Lock the Table Reference

Maybe you are looking to use multiple VLOOKUPs to return different information about a record. If you are planning to copy your VLOOKUP to multiple cells, you will need to lock your table.

The image below shows a VLOOKUP entered incorrectly. The wrong cell ranges are being referenced for the *lookup_value* and *table array*.



ID	Fruit	Quantity	Price	Value
23	Banana	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
34	Apple	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
67	Pomegranate	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
41	Kiwi	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
90	Peach	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
62	Strawberry	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
13	Pear	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
18	Blackberry	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
55	Pineapple	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00

ID	Quantity	Price	Value
41	79	=VLOOKUP(I3,C3:G11,3,FALSE)	

Solution

The table that the VLOOKUP function uses to look for and return information from is known as the *table_array*. This will need to be referenced absolutely to copy your VLOOKUP.

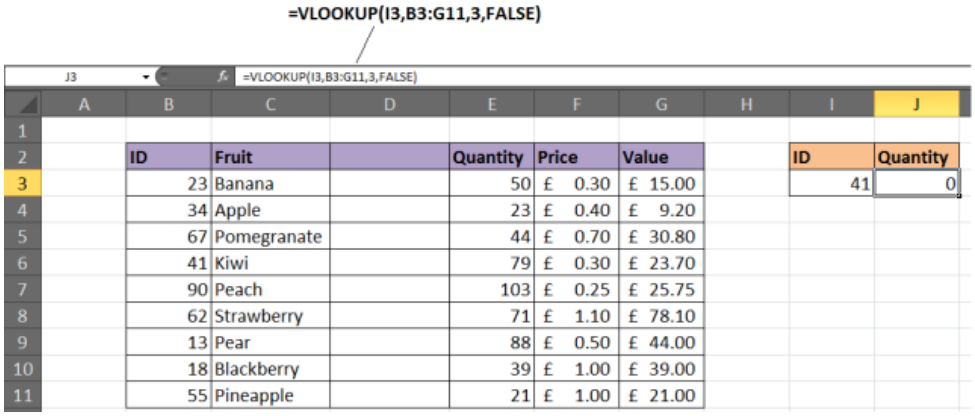
Click on the references within the formula and press the F4 key on the keyboard to change the reference from relative to absolute. The formula should be entered as `=VLOOKUP($H$3,$B$3:$F$11,4,FALSE)`.

In this example both the *lookup_value* and *table_array* references were made absolute. Typically it may be just the *table_array* that needs locking.

A Column Has Been Inserted

The column index number, or *col_index_num*, is used by the VLOOKUP function to enter what information to return about a record.

Because this is entered as an index number, it is not very durable. If a new column is inserted into the table, it could stop your VLOOKUP from working. The image below shows such a scenario.



ID	Fruit		Quantity	Price	Value
23	Banana		50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
34	Apple		23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
67	Pomegranate		44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
41	Kiwi		79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
90	Peach		103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
62	Strawberry		71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
13	Pear		88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
18	Blackberry		39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
55	Pineapple		21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00

ID	Quantity
41	0

The quantity was in column 3, but after a new column was inserted it became column 4. However the VLOOKUP has not automatically updated.

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One solution might be to protect the worksheet so that users cannot insert columns. If users will need to be able to do this, then it is not a viable solution.

Solution 2

Another option would be to insert the MATCH function into the *col_index_num* argument of VLOOKUP.

The `MATCH` function can be used to look for and return the required column number. This makes the *col_index_num* dynamic so inserted columns will no longer affect the VLOOKUP.

The formula below could be entered in this example to prevent the problem demonstrated above.

```
=VLOOKUP(I3,B3:G11,MATCH(J2,B2:G2,0),FALSE)
```

The Table has got Bigger

As more rows are added to the table, the VLOOKUP may need to be updated to ensure that these extra rows are included. The image below shows a VLOOKUP that does not check the entire table for the item of fruit.

132 shares

ID	Fruit	Quantity	Price	Value
23	Banana	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
34	Apple	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
67	Pomegranate	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
41	Kiwi	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
90	Peach	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
62	Strawberry	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
13	Pear	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
18	Blackberry	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
55	Pineapple	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00
77	Grapes	44	£ 1.20	£ 52.80
93	Plum	71	£ 0.60	£ 42.60

ID	Fruit
77	=VLOOKUP(H3,B3:F11,2,FALSE)

VLOOKUP(lookup_value, table_array, col_index_num, [range_lookup])

Solution

Consider formatting the range as a table (Excel 2007+), or as a dynamic range name. These techniques will ensure that your VLOOKUP function will always be checking the entire table.

To format the range as a table, select the range of cells you want to use for the *table_array* and click **Home** > **Format as Table** and select a style from the gallery. Click the **Design** tab under Table Tools and change the table name in the box provided.

The VLOOKUP below shows a table named *FruitList* being used.

ID	Fruit	Quantity	Price	Value
23	Banana	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
34	Apple	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
67	Pomegranate	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
41	Kiwi	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
90	Peach	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
62	Strawberry	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
13	Pear	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
18	Blackberry	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
55	Pineapple	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00
77	Grapes	44	£ 1.20	£ 52.80
93	Plum	71	£ 0.60	£ 42.60

ID	Fruit
77	=VLOOKUP(H3,FruitList,2,FALSE)

VLOOKUP(lookup_value, table_array, col_index_n

A limitation of the VLOOKUP function is that it cannot look to its left. It will look down the leftmost column of a table and return information from the right.

Solution

The solution to this involves not using VLOOKUP at all. Using a combination of the INDEX and MATCH functions of Excel is a common alternative to VLOOKUP. It is far more versatile.

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The example below shows it being used to return information to the left of the column you are looking in.

Learn more about using INDEX and MATCH

=INDEX(B3:B13,MATCH(H3,C3:C13,0))

I3 =INDEX(B3:B13,MATCH(H3,C3:C13,0))

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1									
2		Fruit	ID	Quantity	Price	Value		ID	Fruit
3		Banana	23	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00		62	Strawberry
4		Apple	34	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20			
5		Pomegranate	67	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80			
6		Kiwi	41	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70			
7		Peach	90	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75			
8		Strawberry	62	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10			
9		Pear	13	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00			
10		Blackberry	18	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00			
11		Pineapple	55	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00			
12		Grapes	77	44	£ 1.20	£ 52.80			
13		Plum	93	45	£ 0.60	£ 27.00			

Your Table Contains Duplicates

The VLOOKUP function can only return one record. It will return the first record that matches the value you looked for.

If your table contains duplicates then VLOOKUP will not be up to the task.

Solution 1

Should your list have duplicates? If not consider removing them. A quick way to do this is to select the table and click the **Removes Duplicates** button on the **Data** tab.

Check out the AbleBits Duplicate Remover for a more complete tool for handling duplicates in your Excel tables.

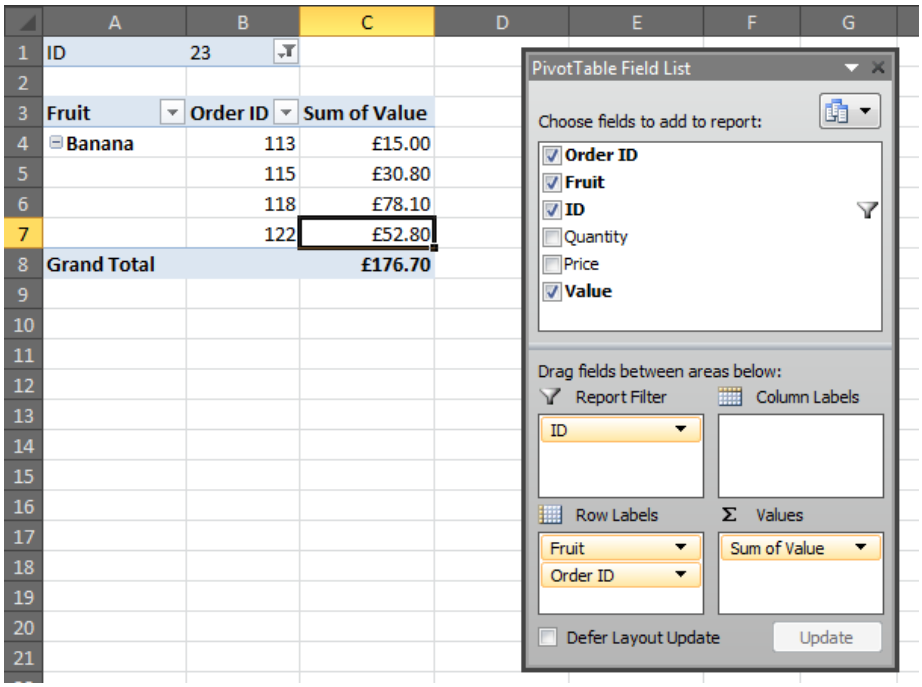
Solution 2

Ok, so your list should have duplicates. In this case a VLOOKUP is not what you need. A PivotTable would be perfect to select a value and list the results instead.

The table below is a list of orders. Let's say you want to return all the orders for a particular fruit.

Order ID	Fruit	ID	Quantity	Price	Value
113	Banana	23	50	£ 0.30	£ 15.00
114	Apple	34	23	£ 0.40	£ 9.20
115	Banana	23	44	£ 0.70	£ 30.80
116	Kiwi	41	79	£ 0.30	£ 23.70
117	Peach	90	103	£ 0.25	£ 25.75
118	Banana	23	71	£ 1.10	£ 78.10
119	Pear	13	88	£ 0.50	£ 44.00
120	Apple	34	39	£ 1.00	£ 39.00
121	Pear	13	21	£ 1.00	£ 21.00
122	Banana	23	44	£ 1.20	£ 52.80
123	Kiwi	41	45	£ 0.60	£ 27.00

A PivotTable has been used to enable a user to select a Fruit ID from the report filter and a list of all the orders appears.



Trouble Free VLOOKUPs

This article demonstrated a solution to the 6 most common reasons a VLOOKUP function is not working. Armed with this information you should enjoy a less troublesome future with this awesome Excel function.

About the Author

Alan Murray is an IT Trainer and the founder of Computergaga. He offers online training and the latest tips and tricks in Excel, Word, PowerPoint and Project.

You may also be interested in:

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112 Responses to "6 Reasons Why Your VLOOKUP is Not Working"

1 *Sripathi Uday Kumar* says:
August 12, 2014 at 10:05 am

Thank you, it was helpful.

Reply

2 *Daniel* says:
October 23, 2014 at 10:06 am

The trapfall of VLOOKUP being not able to "look to right" wasn't known to me before. Very helpful!

Reply

3 *shahram* says:
November 10, 2014 at 7:17 pm

Thank you, it was helpful.

Reply

4 *anil* says:
December 2, 2014 at 4:25 am

when we using vlookup it is show is same number in all colons

Reply

Monih says:
October 25, 2017 at 11:02 am

Me too is facing a similiar error.
Have you got any solution for this.please let me know

Reply

Alan Murray says:
October 30, 2017 at 11:58 am

I'm not sure what you need. Do you mean all columns?
You would need a VLOOKUP in each. A formula can only return to one cell.

Reply

5 *Dan* says:
January 9, 2015 at 10:18 am

Sometimes the error may be because it has not calculated properly. If you have calculation set to manual rather than automatic, this can also cause an error when using vlookup or index match. Once the worksheet calculation is set to automatic, it works again (set it to automatic by going to the Formulas tab and then Calculation Operations and set to Automatic).

Joe says:
February 10, 2015 at 2:26 pm

Dan,

THANK YOU!!! Hours wasted, but many more hours saved. The Automatic setting in Calculation Operations did it. Karma credits in the heapful submitted your way.

Reply

Preeti says:
June 4, 2015 at 8:08 am

Thank u Dan.
I was trying to copy formula and wasted hours. ur just one line comment solved my problem in a tick
:)

Reply

Janne says:
March 21, 2017 at 9:10 am

Thank you so much Dan! This annoying setting has wasted me hours before!

Reply

Kapil says:
March 29, 2017 at 11:49 am

This has saved my hours of hair-pulling ! I have been working with vlookup for a long time now but had not encountered this problem before. Many thanks !

Reply

6 *Silvina* says:
January 14, 2015 at 11:12 am

Thanks a lot! very helpful :)

Reply

7 *Oskar* says:
January 26, 2015 at 1:01 am

thanks a lot for this information

Reply

8 *Brian* says:
April 7, 2015 at 4:27 pm

Hopefully someone can help me. My vlookup is returning the correct values in my columns but it returns the same value until it comes across another non-zero value. For example the correct value of row 10 is 259 but it will return 259 for rows 11, 12, and 13. Row 14 will correctly show 864 but then rows 15 and 16 will too.

Has anyone come across this?

thanks,

Reply

Sergey says:
October 5, 2015 at 8:32 pm

Have the same issue. VLOOKUP is used only for values in ASCENDING order! Try Index Match combination instead.

Reply

9 *Alan Murray* says:
April 8, 2015 at 10:48 am

Hard to say why without seeing the spreadsheet but would expect there to be an error in the lookup value argument. I would check the reference.

Reply

10 *Ahmed* says:
May 18, 2015 at 8:35 am

thank you

Reply

11 *Andy* says:
May 25, 2015 at 3:44 am

Hi Don,

Having calculation set from manual to automatic is very helpful. Save lots of time.

Thank you very much.

Andy

Reply

12 *Tu N* says:
June 17, 2015 at 8:56 pm

Thank you, thank you, thank you for the manual - automatic guide.

Reply

13 *K.Mahedner reddy* says:
July 20, 2015 at 9:49 pm

can any help me put

i had a sheet of name of the employs and their working hours, here the problem is in my sheet i had two names similar...(EX: mahesh as two time in the sheet)

when i use vlookup in the table for my sheet i am not getting the second name

how can i get the second name in the sheet.....by using vlookup

Reply

14 *Alan Murray* says:
July 21, 2015 at 7:18 am

VLOOKUP won't be able to. It will only return the first name from the sheet.

You will need more than 1 VLOOKUP. Or a macro would be needed for multiple occurrances of a name.

Reply

15 *Harshad* says:
July 23, 2015 at 6:01 am

Thanks for sharing. I had some hidden columns so my VLOOKUP was not working! Fixed it after readong Point 3. on your list.

Reply

16 *Kate* says:
August 5, 2015 at 4:24 pm

i am doing a very simple lookup and I am getting the #n/a. Trying to pull a number into my

very simple. I checked to make sure there was a match and there was and no duplicates were found. Help!

Reply

17 *Alan Murray* says:
August 5, 2015 at 8:49 pm

Hard to say exactly without seeing the file. Check that there is definitely a match, so no spaces after the number. And also check the formatting of both the lookup_value and on the table_array to check they are the same.

Reply

18 *Mark W* says:
August 10, 2015 at 9:34 pm

I am trying to write a VLookup formula to bring on hand data into a sheet that details sales volume. My formula is:: =VLOOKUP(A2,AA$2:AB$100,2,FALSE)

Item B1007080SHF3MDO2BS***GG is not present on the target range; Item B1007080SHF3MDO2BSR**GG is there, with a required response value of 409.

When I apply the VLookup to both fields, I get the value of 409 for BOTH, so the 'exact value' part of the formuala does not seem to be working. I have both lists sorted A-Z. It does not seem to matter if I format both columns as text or numbers, same issue (the full data set column does have values that are numbers only & alpha-numeric in both the search criteria and the target range).

Reply

Alan Murray says:
August 11, 2015 at 7:34 am

It looks like the VLOOKUP is using the ** characters as a wildcard.

Reply

19 *Mark W* says:
August 11, 2015 at 1:23 pm

That might be. My ERP system only allows * as special characters so all my item number data exports have * in them. Do you know of a way to prevent this?

Reply

20 *Alan Murray* says:
August 11, 2015 at 1:54 pm

You might be able to concatenate a string. Wrap the * in "" to indicate that you want to refer to that character literally and not as a wildcard.

Otherwise you might be able to use the EXACT function with INDEX and MATCH instead of VLOOKUP. Information on this can be found below.

http://www.computergaga.com/tips/lookup_formulas/case_sensitive_lookup.html

I have not tested this, but think it should work. This function does what its name suggest and ensure the strings match.

Reply

21 *Belinda* says:
August 31, 2015 at 6:18 pm

Watched the YouTube video and it was brilliant instruction!

Saved me loads of time and frustration.

Thanks so much.

22 *Gautam Lapsiya* says:
October 7, 2015 at 11:44 am

Hi,

My table has duplicates in lookup cell, but the value against it is unique, what should I do if I want all the values populated?
e.g
Column A Column B
Banana USA
Watermelon Brazil
Banana Columbia

Now if I want both USA and Columbia in how should I get it, as vlookup only gives USA?

Reply

Alan Murray says:
October 9, 2015 at 9:34 pm

@Gautam Lapsiya Yes the VLOOKUP will only return the first answer.

An option is to use a PivotTable like in the last example.

Alan

Reply

Gautam Lapsiya says:
October 26, 2015 at 12:11 pm

Thanks Alan

Reply

23 *Belinda Nell* says:
January 12, 2016 at 5:31 am

Why does my vlookup give the same answer?

Reply

24 *Kathryn* says:
February 2, 2016 at 8:58 pm

Thank you! My error wasn't any of these, but it was good to be encouraged to look through everything piece by piece. Turns out I had the initial column and the lookup_value formatted differently--one was Number and the other wasn't (somehow...) So, another goofy mistake, but maybe it will help someone.

Reply

25 *Zul* says:
March 1, 2016 at 12:46 pm

Thank you Alan, you helped me with The Table has got Bigger.

Reply

26 *Chris* says:
June 7, 2016 at 10:14 am

VLOOKUP Cannot Look to its Left was my issue.. thanks!

Reply

27 *Amy Kassatly* says:
June 10, 2016 at 4:43 pm

Thank you, the 'VLOOKUP cannot look to its left' was my pain was my issue. Totally unintuitive

28 *Ramprasad* says:
June 12, 2016 at 6:52 pm

Why VLOOKUP with "TRUE" condition is not working on dates?

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 13, 2016 at 6:54 am

It should work with dates no problem. Ensure the table is sorted in earliest to latest by the date.

Reply

29 *Carlo* says:
June 13, 2016 at 7:00 pm

Hi Alan...

Do you have any idea why my VLOOKUP stopped refreshing automatically for ALL my spreadsheets. In your example, when I change I3, I actually have to click into the formula in J3 and hit enter for it to pull the refreshed value.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 13, 2016 at 7:34 pm

Hi Carlo,

I think the cells containing the VLOOKUP's are formatted as text. I would select the cells and check the formatting on the Home tab.

It may also be that you have manual calculation switched on. Click the Formulas tab and then Calculation Options.

Alan

Reply

30 *ABHIJEET* says:
June 15, 2016 at 5:00 am

HI

I want to use VLOOKUP with two diffrent spreadsheet which containt no match value on both, in that case is it possible to apply VLOOKUP in this manner??

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 15, 2016 at 7:29 pm

It is possible to apply a VLOOKUP to two different spreadsheets. Ensure both workbooks are open when you write the VLOOKUP.

Not sure what you mean by the contain no match on both, but VLOOKUP can help check for matches so sounds like it would work.

Reply

31 *Jane* says:
June 28, 2016 at 3:52 pm

Hi - VLOOKUP is working fine for me apart from only returning the first letter, i.e returning only 'J' instead of John. Any ideas?

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 11, 2016 at 9:22 am

Not a clue. VLOOKUP will return all of the content from the cell, so as long as the full name is in there it will work.

Reply

32 *Melanie* says:
July 7, 2016 at 9:19 pm

number could also be stored as text

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 11, 2016 at 9:18 am

Very true. The formatting of the values stored and the one searched for must be consistent.

Reply

Jane says:
July 21, 2016 at 10:29 am

Hi. Thanks for your reply. Unfortunately, it's still not working, even with all values consistent. Totally baffled!

Reply

33 *DHurst* says:
July 12, 2016 at 2:15 am

Hello, Please help me understand why my vlookup formula stops working after 10 matches. My formula is very simple: =VLOOKUP(A7,'compiled responses'!B7:C804,1) my data is very simple: column "a" has numbers, column "b" has numbers

col A col B
404523 404523
447135 447135
447350 447135 this is where the formula stops working as it returns the incorrect value and then the values become N/A.

I have checked the data is has no blanks, both columns are general input.

I look forward to your assistance.

Kindly,
DH

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 12, 2016 at 8:01 pm

I think your VLOOKUP by the sound of it is comparing columns A and B. And in this case it is stopping at that point because it is not a match i.e. 447350 is not equal to 447135.

Reply

34 *Yogananda* says:
July 12, 2016 at 5:33 am

While selecting rows and col in vlookup formula (the area where to search) the row col reference (eg. 8RX4C) is not displaying, It is getting difficult to count manually for larger tables.

Please help me on this issue

Thanks in advance

Reply

Alan Murray says:

I'm struggling a little with the question but I think you are asking about entering the col index num when using a big table.

In such an example the MATCH function can be used to look along the header row and locate the column number for you. This is done in a similar way to the 5th example of this tutorial and in the link below.

http://www.computergaga.com/tips/lookup_formulas/two_way_lookup_using_index_and_m

Reply

35 *Mel* says:
July 27, 2016 at 8:29 am

Hi Alan
I'm doing a VLOOKUP which I do every month to put dates next to asset ID numbers. My LOOKUP results are exactly the same for every ID number when i copy down my formula. So the results for the first row are correct but the rest are wrong as they're the same as the first.

Reply

Alan says:
July 28, 2016 at 8:47 pm

Hi Mel,

It sounds like your lookup_value is absolute so is not changing when you copy the formula.

You might need to remove the dollar signs from the first part of your VLOOKUP.

Alan

Reply

36 *farid* says:
September 3, 2016 at 8:48 am

i want to use vlookup function my data have duplicate value but i don't want to remove it ,so i want use vlookup function but it gave me the first value of duplicate value i want to find the second value that belong to duplicate please help me

Reply

Alan says:
September 4, 2016 at 10:19 pm

Hi Farid,

Check out this video - https://youtu.be/QAZ3L6xbNJc

It shows how to use VLOOKUP to return the last match if there are duplicates. You can adapt this easily for the 2nd match though.

Alan

Reply

37 *Noola* says:
September 5, 2016 at 2:36 pm

Another issue can be "unknown characters" instead of spaces being used. I was looking at a file with 2 sets of data that looked the same, but they were extracted by different means from a database, and on one set of data, spaces were not spaces but some other character. Found it by checking if 2 items that look identical were actually identical (they weren't, according to Excel), and the only possible characters that could be different were those I couldn't see, i.e. spaces.

Reply

Alan says:

Yes sometimes data needs to be cleansed after importing from a database before formulas such as VLOOKUP can be run.

Text functions such as SUBSTITUTE and TRIM are great for this sort of tasks. The Find & Replace and Power Query tools are also brilliant for cleansing data.

Reply

38 *Sergejs* says:
September 11, 2016 at 12:44 pm

Alan,Thank you very much!!!!!

Reply

39 *j* says:
October 19, 2016 at 11:17 pm

can someone please help urgently. i am trying to find the status for the sales but it is only working for the price. pleasee help!!! i don't know what to do!!

USE FUNCTION
Vlookup IF
Brand Products Quantity Price Sales Status Tax
Samsung Projector 15 $1,500.00 $22,500.00 Poor
HP L Printer 20 $1,200.00 $24,000.00 Poor
APPLE Mac/Air 5 $2,200.00 $11,000.00 Poor
Samsung Laptop 10 $1,600.00 $16,000.00 Poor
HP Camera 25 $800.00 $20,000.00 Poor
Samsung Galaxy tab 12 $1,200.00 $14,400.00 Poor
ACER Netbook 18 $900.00 $16,200.00 Poor
DELL DUO/Laptop 13 $2,500.00 $32,500.00 Poor
APPLE Ipad 4 16 $1,400.00 $22,400.00 Poor
TOTAL =>
STATUS more than $30,000.00 Excellent
more than $25,000.00 Good
more than $20,000.00 Average
more than $15,000.00 Trial
less than $15,000.00 Poor

TAX more than $30,000.00 25% Of SALES
more than $25,000.00 20%
more than $20,000.00 15%
more than $15,000.00 10%
less than $15,000.00 5%

Reply

40 *Subbhaiya* says:
October 24, 2016 at 4:08 pm

I am unable to do vlookup between 2 google sheets. 2 sheets are not getting linked.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
November 3, 2016 at 7:05 am

I do not use Google Sheets but am under the impression it works in a similar way. I would re-check the VLOOKUP for potential mistake.

Reply

41 *jahangir* says:
October 30, 2016 at 11:40 am

i make a table using vlookup but its not working properly.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
November 3, 2016 at 7:07 am

I can't really explain without more information. Maybe check the typing of the entries.

You say it works for some and not others. Sounds like a mis-type on those entries not working. Or maybe the second reason above.

Reply

42 *Dee* says:
December 6, 2016 at 9:52 pm

I keep receiving a #REF! error when using a VLOOKUP between two workbooks on a network share.

If I have the VLOOKUP workbook open (showing the #REF! errors) and then I open up the workbook that contains the table array - then the #REF! errors disappear and the cells contain the correct data. It seems as if I must have the source workbook open in order for the link between the two to function correctly. Do you have any suggestions that I could try?

Reply

43 *Simon* says:
December 13, 2016 at 3:37 am

Hi,

I'm trying to use VLOOKUP to look up values with a combination of FS500000, 1000000, F500000. The VLOOKUP is finding combination FS500000 and F500000, however fields with 1000000 are showing the #NA error.
The cells are formatted as general (also tried switching to text), i've removed "hidden" fields and inserted TRIM within the formula, but still no luck.

It's just a simple VLOOKUP formula of =VLOOKUP(A9,Sheet2!A1:K10000,6,FALSE)

Any help would be appreciated.
Thanks.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
December 13, 2016 at 8:12 am

Hi Simon,

I did suspect this would be due to the formatting. General is not adequate, Excel will still view 1000000 as a number.

Formatting as text is good. Just ensure the lookup value and the first column of the table array are the same format. So both need to be text.

Hope it works out.

Alan

Reply

44 *Vinod Vaishnav* says:
January 9, 2017 at 5:54 am

columns values same but rows values change how can use vlookup formula

E.g.

Same Change Value
Name AAAA BBBB CCCC DDDD
A 15 12 16 22
B 45 26 33 99

C 88 33 78 98
B 22 34 56 37

Reply

45 *Siyabonga Nxumalo* says:
February 25, 2017 at 8:12 am

Thank you very much!! It worked. I forgot to lock my table.

Reply

46 *m* says:
March 3, 2017 at 12:26 pm

Thank you guys, great page!

Reply

47 *BERT* says:
March 7, 2017 at 2:48 pm

Hi! I worked in airline company and one task I have is to matched the invoice # to a particular aircraft
I used vlookup but it will only return the first match. Sometime an aircraft comes multiple times in a month. How do I solve this?

Reply

Alan says:
March 14, 2017 at 6:34 am

Yes VLOOKUP will only return the first match. You can use a PivotTable to perform actions like show all invoice # for a particular aircraft.
Otherwise if you wish to populate a bunch of cells with this info then you are looking for a macro probably.

Reply

48 *Alan* says:
March 14, 2017 at 6:34 am

Yes VLOOKUP will only return the first match. You can use a PivotTable to perform actions like show all invoice # for a particular aircraft.

Otherwise if you wish to populate a bunch of cells with this info then you are looking for a macro probably.

Reply

49 *JimmyNZ* says:
March 16, 2017 at 8:45 pm

I have tried all the solutions the article mentioned, still failed then I tried this, always start the looking table with the value you are looking for in the first column e.g. VLOOKUP(sheet1!A2, sheet2!$C$2:$E$84, 1, FALSE). That is you are looking for value in column C in sheet2 that matches value in column A in sheet1. It is magic! to solve a problem of VLOOKUP that happens when we copy data from different data sources.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
March 23, 2017 at 1:40 pm

Thanks for the tip JimmyNZ.

Reply

50 *bill* says:

another tip: if you're looking up numbers, make sure they are not 'numbers formatted as text.' They'll break the formula.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
March 23, 2017 at 1:42 pm

Thanks Bill.

Yes to add to that... the formatting of the lookup value and the first column of the table array must match. Whether they both be numbers, or both be numbers formatted as text, they must be the same.

Reply

51 *Judy* says:
March 30, 2017 at 10:58 pm

My vlookup is only working for the top half of my spreadsheet and then stops working on any cell past row 270. My vlookup table is a named range, first column in order by dates, returning column is to the left of the reference column and formatting matches and is not text. Anyone have a clue how to fix it?

Reply

Alan Murray says:
March 31, 2017 at 11:14 am

Hi Judy, If the VLOOKUP does not look past row 270 I would check out the named range as that would seem the problem. You can edit this named range from the Formulas tab and the Name Manager.

The formatting of the lookup value and first column of the named range must be matching. And the col index num (returning column) must be to the right of the reference column.

The problem in this article on VLOOKUP cannot look to the left can help with this.

Reply

52 *Mnaish Gupta* says:
June 2, 2017 at 6:48 am

Hello Alan,

My vlookup values are too lengthy -
eg values:
1) MCDK904745/MCDK904746;ZCL_IM_CRM_ORDERADM_H_BADI
IF_EX_CRM_ORDERADM_H_BADI~CRM_ORDERADM_H_MERGE
2) MCDK904884/MCDK904885;ZCL_IM_CRM_ORDERADM_I_BADI
IF_EX_CRM_ORDERADM_I_BADI~CRM_ORDERADM_I_MERGE

Thus, when the file is doing a Vlookup for smaller values, they are present, but pulling #NA for these big values. These values are the result of a report so I cannot change these values. But based on these values, I will have to pull data from other columns.

Please advice; what exactly am i missing here and how to tackle this issue

Thanks a lot in advance for all your help

Best regards,

Manish

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 5, 2017 at 7:45 am

Hi Manish,

Th eproblem is that it does not like the Tile "~" in the text. You may need to find a way of

Don't need to remove it from the cell if important. Just temporarily for the lookup. Could use the SUBSTITUTE function in the VLOOKUP.

Alan

Reply

53 *Gerry McArdle* says:
June 2, 2017 at 9:34 am

I have a VLOOKUP problem. I am trying to put the text relating to health hazards into a risk assessment form. So if I select say H302 it puts the text in correctly but other values (they are formatted as text) such as H302+H312 (no spaces) it returns the value for H301 not H302+H312. What am I doing wrong

Reply

Gerry McArdle says:
June 2, 2017 at 12:51 pm

Sorry should say H302 not H301

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 6, 2017 at 7:12 am

Hi Gerry,

Apologies because I am not completely sure what you mean. First thought is to check you have entered False or 0 in the last VLOOKUP argument, so it is not dependent upon order.

I hope you solve the mystery.

Alan

Reply

Gerry McArdle says:
June 12, 2017 at 11:24 am

Alan,

Thank you, I had omitted the FALSE entry. Everything is fine now.

Gerry

Reply

Alan Murray says:
June 12, 2017 at 4:36 pm

Great to hear. Thanks for letting me know Gerry.

Reply

54 *Molly* says:
June 27, 2017 at 4:35 pm

Hi Alan

Great site and thanks so much for the time you take helping us all!

My issue is I have brought in data from 2 different user's spreadsheets and the source data has leading zeros. We used a custom format o############ for both source and Col.A of Vlookup table - but the source data shows in the formula bar the leading zero whereas the vlookup col A does not show the leading zero in the formula bar and thinking this is why I keep getting N/A?

Reply

Alan Murray says:

Hi Molly, thank you.

Yes the format of both columns must be the same for VLOOKUP. If the zeros are showing in the formula bar, it sounds like it is stored as text.

You could use the VALUE function on that columns data to convert it from text representing a number to a number.

Then try the VLOOKUP using that columns data. Good luck :)

Reply

Cathy H says:
July 7, 2017 at 2:26 pm

This is helpful. Can you tell me how to convert from special to general without losing the leading zero's?
thank you!

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 9, 2017 at 9:00 am

Hi Cathy H,

You can try formatting the values as Text from that menu instead of General.

Or use a formula in a different column such as

=TEXT(A1, "00000")

This example assumes your number is in A1 and you need 5 numbers including leading zeros.

These results can then be copied and paste values over the current ones. This will change the format to text but keep the zeros.

Hope that helps

Alan

Reply

55 *Keith* says:
July 4, 2017 at 8:41 am

Hi Alan,
One work sheet, let say there are thousand of row, lookup value is the same format cell, table array no problem, column index no problem, range lookup is "0"), but the result is different at below:-

7015028 CHUAN HUP SENG CHUAN HUP SENG
7043640 SIN NAM HONG CAFÉ #N/A

The only differences found is the lookup value cell. 7015028 has a caution mark at top left saying "The number in this cell is formatted as text or preceded by an apostrophe", where 7043640 is normal cell. Both cell format as GENERAL.

Thanks.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 9, 2017 at 8:55 am

Hi Keith,

Ok yes, if that column is the first of the table array and being used as the lookup value, then the format of both must match up.

The one with the apostrophe is stored as text, the other is a number. Ignore the general along the top. One is text here and one is a number.

This could be done by selecting them as choosing Text from the menu that currently displays general.

If this does not work, you could use this formula in an adjacent column

=TEXT(A1,"0000000")

Then copy and paste values the results over the current table array cells.

Hope this helps

Alan

Reply

56 *Annie* says:
July 13, 2017 at 4:29 am

Hi Alan,

I am new to lookup function so I tried as per your instructions (even copied the exact data as yours) but it still doesn't work. What did I do wrong. Please help.

Thanks
Annie

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 17, 2017 at 7:33 am

Hi Annie,

Without seeing what you have I cannot really help with this.

It is typically one of the situations mentioned in this article, but to know exactly what is going on I would need to see the spreadsheet + formula.

Alan

Reply

57 *rhythm* says:
July 17, 2017 at 3:48 pm

Indeed very helpful. Thanks.

Reply

58 *Madalin* says:
July 18, 2017 at 2:30 pm

Hello,

I have an issue with the vlookup/match.

For my case, the lookup value is not a value that I insert as input, but a formula. For example in A1=1 and A2=A1+1.
The vlookup/match function is not behaving normal when I am looking for A2 in a table, ..sometimes it shows the N/A error and sometimes it works. If instead I write over in A2=2, then it works 100%.
Because of the large number of data, this is not preferable for my case.
Is there any solution for this issue?

Thank you!
Madalin

Reply

Alan Murray says:
July 18, 2017 at 7:40 pm

Its always hard to say without seeing it but I would guess it to be an issue with formatting.

Reply

Madalin says:
July 19, 2017 at 6:47 am

Here is a sample of my data..it is possible that is not the optimum way to do it this way :)

A1=2.9, A2=3, A3=3.1, A4-3.2, A5=3.3, B1=12.5, B2=18.2, B3=25.3, B4=33, B5=45,

A7=30

A9=MAX(IF(B1:B5<$A$7,B1:B5)) (=25.3)

A11=INDEX($A$1:$A$5,MATCH(A9,B1:B5,0)) (=3.1)
A12=A11+0.1 (=3.2)
A13=A12+0.1 (=3.3)

A15=INDEX(B1:B5,MATCH(A11,$A$1:$A$5,0)) (=25.3)
A16=INDEX(B1:B5,MATCH(A12,$A$1:$A$5,0)) (=33)
A17=INDEX(B1:B5,MATCH(A13,$A$1:$A$5,0)) (=N/A)

If I change A13=3.3, then A17=45

Thank you!
Madalin

Reply

59 *Archana* says:
December 4, 2017 at 7:13 am

Hi, My query is i want to use vlookup in book 1 sheet 1, with book 2 to pull out the data, so in book 2 it is not taking the formula. Please help.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
December 4, 2017 at 8:34 am

You should be able to set this up in the same way as if they were just in 2 different sheets. Make sure Book1 is open when you begin the VLOOKUP in Book2 and you should be able to select Book1 and then Sheet 1 to highlight the Table Array.
The finished VLOOKUP will be as normal with the Table array showing [Book1.xlsx]Sheet1! at the start.

Reply

60 *Abdallah* says:
December 8, 2017 at 8:39 am

WOW , it's first time i know "VLOOKUP Cannot Look to its Left " this cause me lose more time . for years i don't know why Vlookup sometimes work and sometimes not :) .
Thanks guys

Reply

Alan Murray says:
December 10, 2017 at 6:38 pm

You're welcome Abdallah.

Reply

61 *Saroj K Subedi* says:
December 24, 2017 at 7:31 am

Dear Sir,
I am working with vlookup function since a long time,but nowadays I got my results with some N/A results as unique value is common in both tables and resulting data also presents there but also results N/A for some rows.Please suggest..

Alan Murray says:
December 24, 2017 at 8:56 am

Sorry Saroj, I don't understand your question.

The #N/A error will be present if it cannot find what you are looking for. It may be that the formatting of what you are looking for and where you are looking do not match.

Reply

62 *Sally* says:
January 16, 2018 at 4:58 pm

Hi

I'm trying to do a basic V-look up and once I've entered it, and hit return on the first cell, all the cell displays is the formula, it doesn't pull any information. I've had this before but can't remember the fix.

So instead of showing the result I'm looking for, my cell displays as follows:

=VLOOKUP(C2,Sheet2!A:B,2,0)

Any ideas please?

Thanks

Sally

Reply

Alan Murray says:
January 16, 2018 at 10:17 pm

Hi Sally,
It could be that the cell containing the formula is formatted as text. Check the drop down halfway on the Home tab.
Or maybe formulas are set to be displayed. Check the Show Formulas button on the Formulas tab.
Alan

Reply

63 *Paola G* says:
April 10, 2018 at 10:28 pm

You are awesome! Thank you.

Reply

64 *Alan Murray* says:
April 11, 2018 at 6:10 am

You're welcome Paola.

Reply

65 *Paul Wamalwa* says:
April 24, 2018 at 9:22 am

Thank you so much, you have saved me of worries. May you live long brother

Reply

Alan Murray says:
April 25, 2018 at 7:01 am

Thank you Paul.

Reply

66 *Julian H* says:

Another mistake is to check your reference list for duplicates. If you think the lookup value is only in there once, you may be mystified as to why the correct value is not being returned, but Vlookup is bringing back the first instance it finds.

Reply

Alan Murray says:
May 8, 2018 at 12:47 pm

Thank you for your comment Julian.

Reply

Post a comment

Name Name

name@example.com E-mail (not published)

Send

Unfortunately, due to the volume of comments received we cannot guarantee that we will be able to give you a timely response. When posting a question, please be very clear and concise. We thank you for understanding!

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